

THE SMB PLAYBOOK

Stop Subsidizing the Algorithm: How SMBs Win When Ad Platforms Run on Autopilot

The execution is automated. The judgment isn't.

Published September 2026 · Updated October 2026

You're not running a media plan — you're running a Meta account, maybe a Google account, and a bank balance that tells you more than any dashboard does. That's not a gap in your strategy. It's what the platforms designed for.

The platforms are betting you won't have time to watch what their "smart" campaigns are actually doing with your money — automated bidding needs a budget it can move around freely, and the less you watch it, the more freely it moves.

This isn't a strategy guide. It's a short list of guardrails so the algorithm works for your cash flow instead of the other way around.

02 — THE THREE WORDS THAT MATTER MORE THAN THE DASHBOARD

Cash in, versus platform spend, versus how many days it took to get that cash back.

That's it. Ignore impressions, cost-per-click, and reach — they're what the platform wants you watching because they always look fine. If a platform's dashboard is telling you a different story than your bank account, believe the bank account.

"Give us a budget and a goal, we'll handle the rest" — useful, only inside guardrails you set.

Every major platform now runs some version of this: Google Performance Max, Meta Advantage+, and — for sellers with an Amazon storefront — Amazon's self-service ad platform and its auto-bidding. Set these before you turn any automated campaign on, and check them monthly:

- **A hard budget cap**, not a "daily average" — automated campaigns will spend unevenly day to day if you let them.
- **A real return floor (ROAS — revenue divided by ad spend)**. Decide the minimum return you'll accept before you launch, not after you see a month of results. If the campaign can't hit it, it pauses — automatically if the platform allows it, manually if it doesn't.
- **A manual exclusion list**. Your own brand name, your existing customer list, and any placement categories you don't want — excluded explicitly. Left unset, "smart" campaigns tend to spend on the easiest conversions available, which is often traffic you already had for free.
- **A review date on your calendar**, not "whenever I think to check." Once a month, minimum.

If you sell anything with a catalog, this matters more than any ad copy you write.

AI shopping tools are starting to read product catalogs directly. ChatGPT is already transacting from them through retailer integrations; Google's AI-driven shopping surfaces are starting to recommend from them the same way — both without the shopper necessarily seeing your website or an ad. If your feed data is messy, incomplete, or missing attributes, you don't show up.

- Every product has a clear, accurate title and description — no keyword-stuffing, no missing fields.
- Category, brand, and identifier fields (the barcode/product-ID fields — GTIN, UPC, or MPN) are filled in, not left blank.
- Pricing and availability in the feed match what's actually on the site in real time.

If you don't know whether your feed currently meets this bar, that's the first thing to check — before spending anything else on ads pointing at that catalog.

05 — THE HABIT TAX, AT YOUR SIZE

At enterprise size, a drifting media plan wastes budget nobody notices for a quarter. At your size, you feel it in cash flow within weeks.

A campaign keeps running because turning it off feels like giving up on it, not because anyone checked whether it's still profitable. None of these are bad decisions in isolation. Add them up over a few months and they're the reason cash feels tight even though "the ads are running fine." The fix isn't a bigger budget — it's the guardrails in Section 03, checked on a calendar, not from memory.

06 — MISTAKES TO AVOID

- **Turning on automated bidding with no guardrails set.** The platform will spend efficiently toward whatever goal you gave it — not the same as spending efficiently toward staying in business.
- **Watching platform metrics instead of cash.** Reach and click-through rates can look great while margin quietly disappears.
- **Letting retargeting run against your whole customer list** — you end up paying to "acquire" people who were going to buy anyway.
- **Ignoring your product feed until sales drop.** By then it's not a quick fix.
- **Waiting for a slow month to check any of this.** The check should happen every month, not just the bad ones.

07 — WHAT TO DO THIS WEEK

- 1 Set (or check) a ROAS floor and exclusion list on every automated campaign you're running.
- 2 Pull your last 30 days of "new conversions" and check how many are actually your own brand name or existing customers.
- 3 Spend 15 minutes on your product feed — pick your top 10 SKUs by revenue and make sure every field is complete.
- 4 Put a recurring monthly date on your calendar to redo steps 1–3. That's the whole system.

ABOUT ORBIS TEAM

Orbis Team is an independent programmatic, CTV, and retail media practice, built by practitioners with 35+ years of combined experience buying paid media for national and regional brands. Anyone who makes money when you spend more is not the person to ask whether you should spend less. That's why we add no markup to media, and our fee isn't tied to your media spend.

The execution is automated. The judgment isn't.

orbisteam.com